

Negation through reduplication in the Caucasus

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This talk will address the use of stem reduplication in verbal negation in two branches of the North East Caucasian family, Dargic (Kubachi and Icari Dargwa) and Lezgif (Tabasaran), from a descriptive and typological viewpoint and will offer a tentative diachronic explanation of how reduplication became one of the standard verbal negation strategies in these languages.

Partial or total stem reduplication as a concomitant exponent of negation together with a negative affix is morphologically atypical and cross-linguistically extremely rare. It is only marginally attested in the world's languages (Dahl 1979, 2010, Miestamo 2005, Bond 2016). First reported for Tabasaran in Dahl (1979), it has since been documented in Chepang (Sino-Tibetan), Coast Tarangan (Austronesian), Banda-Linda, Eleme and Mono (Niger-Congo) (Bond 2016). Of these, only Tabasaran and Eleme seem to have it in some cases as the only, albeit severely restricted in terms of verb types and TAM values, exponent of negation.

Indeed, in Tabasaran, **only three-syllable verbs** reduplicate their second syllable in their indicative eventual negative forms, as well as their non-indicative and (non-)finite negative forms. Compare the following examples in the eventual (personal knowledge).

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|-----|----|-----------------------|----|---------------------------------|
| (1) | a. | <i>dar-ap'-ar-za</i> | b. | <i>alala xh-ar-za</i> |
| | | NEG-do.IPFV-EVT-1SG.A | | REDUP.N.dress.IPFV-EVT-1SG.A |
| | | 'I will not do it.' | | 'I will not dress.' |

In example 1a the one-syllable verb stem *ap'*- 'to do' exhibits the negative prefix *dVr*-, whereas in 1b the three-syllable verb stem *a-la- xh*- 'to dress' exhibits reduplication of its second syllable as the only marker of negation.

On the other hand, in two hitherto unmentioned in the literature on negation Dargic languages, Kubachi (Magometov 1963) and Icari (Sumbatova & Mutalov 2003), negation of synthetic verb forms is expressed through the reduplication of the verb stem (cf. example 2).

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|-----|----|-----------------|----|-----------------------|
| (2) | a. | <i>b-āq'-ad</i> | b. | <i>b-āq' ~ āq'-ad</i> |
| | | N-do.PFV-1.PST | | N-REDUP~do.PFV-1.PST |
| | | 'I did it.' | | 'I didn't do it.' |

By contrast, in the other Dargic languages we find a negative prefix on the negated verb (cf. the Tsugni Dargwa examples in 3, personal knowledge).

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|-----|----|-----------------------|----|--------------------------------------|
| (3) | a. | <i>rurs:i r-ax-aj</i> | b. | <i>rurs:i ʔa^r-r-ax-aj</i> |
| | | girl F-go.IPFV-3.PST | | girl NEG-F-go.IPFV-3.PST |
| | | 'The girl walked.' | | 'The girl did not walk.' |

Interestingly, in these other languages, it is possible to place a copy of the stem (with the class marker) before the negative prefix for an emphatic negative, cf. Tsugni *r-ax-ʔa^r-r-ax-aj* (F-go.IPFV-NEG-F-go.IPFV-3.PST) 'she didn't walk **at all**'. Kubachi and Icari seem thus to have grammaticalized this emphatic negation as their standard negation. The class marker on the verb stem and the negative prefix have been lost, leaving the reduplicated stem as the only exponent of negation.

However, this analysis fails to account for the following Kubachi examples.

¹The Chepang data is controversial as the most up-to-date grammar of the language (Pons 2022) does not mention this 'negative emphasis' (Caughley 1982).

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| (4) a. <i>b-at-ad</i>
N-leave.PFV-1.PST
‘I left it.’ | b. <i>b-at ~ āt-ad</i>
N-REDUP~leave.PFV-1.PST
‘I didn’t leave it.’ |
| (5) a. <i>b-īq’-id</i>
N-do.IPFV-1SG.EVT
‘I do it.’ | b. <i>b-īq’ ~ ēq’-id</i>
N-REDUP~do.IPFV-1SG.EVT
‘I don’t do it.’ |

In example 4, the reduplicated stem’s vowel is short (*b-at ~ āt-ad*), as in the affirmative (*b-at-ad*), whereas the second occurrence of this vowel in the negative form (*b-at ~ āt-ad*) is long. This can be readily explained by the fact that the Dargic negative verb prefix (*ʔaʔ*- in Tsugni) shows up in the other languages as *ʔaʔ*(ʔ)-, *Haʔ*(ʔ)- or *a-*, as in the case of Kubachi where *b-at ~ āt-ad* derives underlyingly from *b-at-a-at-ad* (N-leave.PFV-NEG-leave.PFV-1.PST). This becomes even clearer from example 5b. The form *-ēq’* is transparently the result of vowel coalescence: the negative prefix *a-* has historically coalesced with the initial vowel of the stem of the imperfective verb stem *īq’*- ‘to do’, i.e. *b-īq’-a-īq’-> b-īq’ēq’-*. A similar situation, but at a more advanced stage, obtains in Icari as the length of the resulting vowel depends on the presence or absence of a preconsonantal liquid in the verb stem (Sumbatova & Mutalov 2003: pp. 61–2).

Apart from the cross-linguistic tendency observed to add emphasis to non-emphatic constructions over time, we will consider the genesis of the reduplication of the verb stem as a means of expressing negation in these NE Caucasian languages against the backdrop of the predicate topicalization strategies used across the family. In one of these, the non-finite form appears in the left periphery of the clause, while the fully inflected verb occupies its usual place, resulting in constituents of the type ‘As for Ving, (s)he Ved, [but...]’ where the verb is reduplicated (Maisak 2012).

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